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Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, MAY 27, 2026 • \$4

Double loss for GOP in midterm map wars

Party leaders balk in South Carolina, and judge blocks Alabama redraw

BY PATRICK MARLEY

Republicans faced twin setbacks Tuesday in their plans to redraw congressional maps ahead of the midterm elections, with members of their own party blocking new districts in South Carolina and a federal court halting them in Alabama.

The failure to approve a new map in South Carolina preserved the district of Rep. James E. Clyburn, a power broker within the Democratic Party and the first Black member of Congress elected from the state in nearly a century. His district was kept intact when a contingent of Republicans in the state Senate joined with Democrats to prevent approval of a new map.

Those plans sputtered out just hours after a federal court blocked Alabama from using a map designed to give Republicans an edge in six of seven congressional districts in the state. That victory for Democrats may be fleeting, as Republicans in the state promised to appeal the decision to the Supreme Court.

The unanimous three-judge panel ruled that Alabama could not use its map because the panel had years ago determined it “represents an intentional effort to crack the Black population in Alabama.”

Republicans across the South in recent weeks have sought to take advantage of a Supreme Court decision that makes it easier to draw congressional districts in their favor. The decision, which weakened the Voting Rights Act, is likely to diminish the number

SEE REPUBLICANS ON A2



KEVIN DIETSCH/GETTY IMAGES

Work continues Tuesday on the construction of the ballroom, seen at right, as well as, separately, a UFC cage on the South Lawn, at left.

President erupts at ballroom hurdles

BY DAN DIAMOND

President Donald Trump has made little secret that his planned White House ballroom is a top priority, invoking the project more frequently than most other issues. And in recent weeks he has raged at anyone — including a federal judge, a Senate official and a local historian — whose actions threaten to slow construction.

On Monday, the president shared on social media a copy of a legal filing that closely resembled his own words and contended that the weekend’s shooting outside the White House campus proved the need for a ballroom.

“Without the construction of

He aims to move quickly but has been constrained by courts and Congress

this great Project, the President cannot safely conduct the business of the United States,” acting attorney general Todd Blanche and two other senior Justice Department officials lawyers wrote, urging a federal judge to dissolve his order that could soon halt construction. “This is a terrible, tremendously harmful case to the United States of America, and all it stands for!”

The filing also mocked the

National Trust for Historic Preservation, which has sued to halt the project, claiming that the group had been “defunded by Congress due to a total lack of respect for them.” Trump posted all six pages of the filing on his Truth Social platform.

Trump’s ballroom project has embodied executive power and its limitations.

The president was able to rapidly bulldoze the East Wing last year, clearing space for his planned 90,000-square-foot addition. Trump has remade independent federal commissions — firing holdovers and installing loyalists, including his executive assistant — that have swiftly approved his project. He’s raised

vast sums of money that he says can be put toward the ballroom’s estimated \$400 million cost.

But so far, he has been constrained — barely — by the courts and Congress.

U.S. District Judge Richard Leon has twice sided with the National Trust, ordering a pause on the aboveground components of the ballroom until Congress formally authorizes the project. Leon also criticized the administration’s plan to use private donations to pay for the project, calling it a “Rube Goldberg” contraption that was structured in an attempt to evade congressional oversight. A federal appeals panel stayed Leon’s order

SEE TRUMP ON A5

Truces buckle on two fronts

ISRAEL, HEZBOLLAH BATTLE IN LEBANON

Tehran threatens to retaliate after U.S. strikes

This article is by Sammy Westfall, Mohamad El Chamaa, Suzan Haidamous, Lior Soroka and Susannah George

Fighting between Israel and Hezbollah intensified Tuesday as Tehran threatened to retaliate after overnight U.S. strikes on Iran. The fragile ceasefires on both fronts have come under increasing strain.

Israel is “deepening its operation” in Lebanon, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said, as the Israel Defense Forces pushed beyond the demarcation zone established in a U.S.-brokered ceasefire last month, forcing civilians to flee.

“The IDF is operating with large forces on the ground and seizing dominant terrain,” Netanyahu said at a security cabinet meeting on Tuesday.

Israel’s military is operating in a “targeted manner beyond the Forward Defense Line in Lebanon” to remove “direct threats ... in accordance with the directives of the political echelon,” said an Israeli military official, speaking on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive details.

Despite the ceasefire, Israel and Hezbollah have continued to trade attacks. More than 700 people have been killed in Lebanon

SEE MIDDLE EAST ON A11

Peace points: What to know about the potential deal with Iran. A11

Rubio, in India, leans into pageantry

BY JOHN HUDSON

NEW DELHI — In the span of four days, Secretary of State Marco Rubio lit prayer candles with the nuns of Kolkata, gripped hands with India’s prime minister in New Delhi, toured the Taj Mahal in 100-plus degree heat and cheered on folk musicians performing atop elephants in Jaipur.

The dizzying array of cultural and political events is aimed at mending a relationship with the world’s largest democracy that has soured by dint of President Donald Trump’s sweeping tariff agenda, overtures to China and high-profile embrace of archival Pakistan, which India has long sought to isolate.

He seeks to repair frayed relations over tariffs, U.S. embrace of Pakistan

The hurt feelings surfaced publicly on Rubio’s second stop when an Indian journalist told him that Trump’s second term has diverged from “25 years of very significant progress in India-U.S. ties,” introduced a “transactional” approach to the relationship and sent “mixed signals on Pakistan and China” that left many in India feeling that momentum has been “lost.”

Rubio rejected the premise,

saying “the relationship continues to be strong,” but U.S. officials across the departments of commerce, state and defense acknowledge that Washington is digging itself out of a hole with India and hopes to return to the warmer bilateral rapport of Trump’s first term.

“This is a damage-control trip,” said Husain Haqqani, a senior fellow at the Hudson Institute, a conservative think tank in Washington.

“U.S.-India relations have really gone down as a result of a clash between Trump’s vanity and Modi’s pride,” he added, referring to Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

SEE RUBIO ON A12

Evacuated U.S. doctor fears for his colleagues

BY LAUREN WEBER

Murmurs of a “casket disease” had already begun by mid-May, as patients began to die in waves.

Patrick LaRochelle, an American missionary physician, was 20 minutes away from getting on a plane out of the Democratic Republic of Congo, part of his journey with his wife and three kids back home to the United States for a summer visit.

Then he got a WhatsApp message: Ebola was here.

Suddenly, the mysterious illness sweeping the hospital he worked at in Bunia made sense.

Says he feels ‘helpless’ as cases linked to deadly Ebola outbreak top 1,000

And his health risk became clear. Now surrounded in a plastic bubble sheathed in protective gear in Prague and asymptomatic as of Monday, the internist and pediatrician said in a Zoom interview that he’s grateful for the care he’s received. LaRochelle, who was evacuated once before for an Ebola exposure in 2018, added

that he’s aware many of his colleagues are working without sufficient safeguards.

LaRochelle’s comments, the first he’s made to a reporter since his evacuation, come as medical and aid workers in Congo are struggling to respond to an Ebola outbreak that is already linked to over 1,000 cases.

“The two times, perhaps, that I’ve been most proud to be an American in the last 10 years have been when I’ve been evacuated,” he said. “What hurts is knowing that that is not available to the vast majority of people, and certainly

SEE EBOLA ON A10

SONNY ROLLINS 1930-2026



ROBERT VOS/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Jazz ‘colossus’ of tradition and innovation

Tenor saxophonist was one of America’s most renowned musicians

BY MATT SCHUDEL

Sonny Rollins, the “saxophone colossus” who was widely considered America’s greatest living jazz musician and whose musical eloquence and inventiveness kept him at the creative forefront of jazz for six decades, died May 25 at his home in Woodstock, New York. He was 95.

His death was announced in a statement

shared by his publicist, Terri Hinte. Mr. Rollins had stopped performing more than a decade ago because of pulmonary fibrosis.

Mr. Rollins embodied seemingly contradictory impulses: tradition and innovation, delicacy and strength, bravado and reticence. In concert, he sent a jolt of exhilaration surging through the crowd as he improvised intricate melodies without sounding trite or

SEE ROLLINS ON A8

Sonny Rollins performs in Rotterdam, at the Dutch jazz festival North Sea Jazz, in 2010.

IN THE NEWS

Crackdown on leaks The White House is planning a government-wide nondisclosure agreement that would bar federal workers from sharing a wide array of information. A3

John Eaton, 91 Over his long career, the celebrated jazz pianist helped draw renewed attention to the Great American Songbook. B13

THE NATION Black members of Congress focus on “massive” turnout after civil rights law was weakened. A3
Blue Origin secured a contract to deliver lunar rovers and other equipment to the moon. A6

THE WORLD With China showing a greater willingness to strong-arm neighbors, Japan and South Korea are banding together as smaller nations redraw the geostrategic balance in Asia. A9

THE ECONOMY Graduation gifts are big business, topping \$7 billion this year by one estimate. What to do when you receive an announcement that feels like an invoice. A13
Anthropic co-founder Christopher Olah helped Pope Leo unveil an encyclical on AI’s risks. A13

STYLE Social media is quickly becoming a place to save regional American accents, contrary to fears of homogenization. B1

SPORTS Meet the 26 men who will represent America at this summer’s World Cup in the U.S., Canada and Mexico. B7

THE REGION The side of D.C. that many never see: rare glimpses inside historic and opulent ambassador residences. B13

FOOD Wash your hands, preheat the oven and more vital things you should always do even if a recipe doesn’t say to.

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The Washington Post
Year 149, No. 54594

